

says. That, and live in Delhi. What started out with five enthusiasts increased to 42 members in the first year, and has now whittled down to 26 hardcore bikers.

Since then, the group has burnt rubber over approximately 7,000 km. "We prefer the sky to the sunroof," says 20-year-old Akash Nijhawan. That, and a love for cruising open highways.

So whenever possible, the members hit the road, stopping at wayside dhabs and little villages. "You can feel our culture sitting at a dhaba," says fellow-biker and 21-year-old business studies student Shubham Gupta. They often head into villages to speak to the people and learn more about them. They travel together—their longest trip being to Dhanaulti and Mussoorie this year—and dream of going farther, to explore and experience the country. Before the end of this year, they plan to head to the Wagah border and to Jaisalmer in Rajasthan.

The bond between them has grown.

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WAS WHEN
THE FIRST
BIKER CLUB
WAS BORN IN
THE US

When they aren't talking motorcycles, they discuss politics, music, girls, and often, personal and family matters. Many of them are single and others committed to a relationship, and they turn to each other whenever they are in need of advice, says 22-year-old law student Lalit Valecha, the group's treasurer. The Thugs also want to do their bit and give something back to the world, says Agarwal. So the members have decided to use the club's monthly fee—a nominal Rs 50 per head per month—to make an annual contribution to a non-profit organisation.

Colourful bandanas and dark glasses in place, the Thugs now decide to make a pit stop at a dhaba. Then it's back to the road for them. It's the roar of their motorcycles, the thump that calls to them, bringing with it a promise of adventure and the chance to rediscover free India—one that most of their compatriots have forgotten in the hurly-burly of urban life.

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SHUBHAM GUPTA

MEAN MACHINES:
The bikers with
their Thunderbirds

